IBridge

The inhabited bridge: the public face of privacy[1]

Sol Sadeghi[2]

Introduction

How does a bridge straddle the line between passage, barrier and inhabitation? More than a feat of engineering, the inhabited bridge was historically a complex urban form: a controlled crossing, a place of dwelling, a site of commerce and an arena in which authority, devotion and everyday life converged. Suspended between shores yet deeply embedded in civic life, such bridges operated not merely as connective infrastructures but as inhabited thresholds, urban gateways through which people, goods, rituals and ideas continuously passed, paused and encountered one another. Their significance, therefore, lies not only in their structural or economic role but in the ways in which they reveal how public space became regulated, inhabited and increasingly privatised.

This chapter examines the Old London Bridge as one of early modern Europe's most remarkable examples of inhabited infrastructure. From its medieval construction to

[1] Sadeghi, Sol. "The Inhabited Bridge: The Public Face of Privacy." In *Building Early Modern Privacy: A Combined Spatial and Social Perspective*, edited by Natalie Patricia Körner, Johannes Ljungberg, Mette Birkedal Bruun, and Peter Thule Kristensen. UCL Press, forthcoming.
https://zenodo.org/records/21195315
[2] Royal Danish Academy

1759, London Bridge was more than a crossing over the Thames; it was a densely inhabited corridor of houses and shops, a site of worship, a place of punishment, a commercial route and a jurisdictional threshold between the City and Southwark. Carrying pedestrians, carts, animals, traders, pilgrims and residents within a narrow-built fabric, the bridge functioned as a civic interior – part street, part neighbourhood, part institution, one where circulation and habitation, public authority and private life unfolded within the same architectural frame.

Its architectural and social complexity makes London Bridge a revealing lens through which to examine privacy. Privacy is understood here not as a fixed or universal condition, but as historically situated, relational and spatially produced, shaped by changing relations between bodies, institutions and the built environment.[3] Following David Vincent's notion of 'privacy before privacy', this chapter examines forms of seclusion, intimacy, bodily care, conscience and personal claim before privacy emerged as a modern liberal right.[4] As Diane Shaw argues, the notion that medieval society lacked privacy altogether is a mistaken assertion rooted in modern assumptions that privacy must be solitary and inviolable; rather, privacy often operated as a shared, situational and socially negotiated condition.[5] By 'public privacy', I refer to forms of intimacy and withdrawal enacted within shared and publicly visible environments rather than protected behind domestic enclosure. In this sense, public privacy may also be understood as a form of 'cultural production', shaped through ritual, performance, legal contestation and shared practices within public settings.[6] In this context, privatisation refers not simply to ownership but

[3] de Groot and van der Sloot, *The Handbook of Privacy Studies*.
[4] Vincent, *Privacy.*
[5] Shaw, 'The construction of the private in medieval London', 1996, 450.
[6] Vanhaelen and Ward, *Making Space Public in Early Modern Europe.*

also to the enclosure, appropriation and differentiated control of shared urban infrastructure.

This chapter argues that privacy in early modern London was often negotiated in public. London Bridge functioned as a privatised public path on which such forms were continually shaped, contested and performed. Rooted in medieval foundations yet focused on the formative early modern period c.1500–1666, this chapter integrates architectural history with the history of habitation to show how spatial transformations – from St Thomas' Chapel and the growth of tenements to public privies and the remaking of bridge gates into spaces of punishment – reshaped the relationship between public life and private claims. Through these transformations, London Bridge became a stage for the public production of privacy.

As a suspended linear city of non-linear privacy, London Bridge reveals how private life unfolded unevenly across sacred, domestic and punitive spaces. Its linear form concentrated movement, habitation, commerce and governance into a compressed urban corridor, yet the privacies it produced were layered, fragmented and socially differentiated. Some were devotional and communal; others were domestic and juridical; yet others were shaped by authority through what may be called an architecture of exposure in which bodies, beliefs and behaviours were made publicly visible, disciplined and remembered. In each case, privacy emerged not outside the public realm but through it.

The following sections unfold through three spatial forms of privacy located on London Bridge: the chapel, the tenements and the bridge gates. Together, these spaces show that London Bridge was not merely an urban corridor but a living laboratory in which the relationship between privatisation, infrastructure and privacy was materially shaped, spatially organised and politically negotiated in early modern Europe.

Fig.1 Old London Bridge as inhabited urban infrastructure in Claes Jansz. Visscher's Panorama of London (1616; reproduced 1848).
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St Dunstan in the east
St Hellen
St Andrew
Allhallows Barking
Hackney
London Stone
THE BRIDGE
Bridge Gate
St Mary Overis

IBridge

IBridge
Inhabited Bridges in a Privacy Perspective

Royal Danish Academy
Philip de Langes Allé 10
1435 Copenhagen K

skh@kglakademi.dk
smz.sdgh@gmail.com

https://www.zenodo.org/communities/ibridg

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